Weather and tides

Winter

Gales come from the south-west and bring a steep, short sea to the harbor mouth. Boats stay on their moorings, and the quay is closed to visitors when the spray reaches the lamp posts.

Between gales the air is often clear and cold. The tide tables are most reliable in these weeks, because the wind does not push extra water into the bay.

Spring

The wind turns to the east and the fog begins. It rises in the afternoon and lies over the water until the next morning, so the fog signal is sounded from dusk onwards.

The first fishing boats leave before dawn and return with the tide. Their catch is weighed on the quay and sold from the carts.

Summer

Light winds and long evenings fill the town with visitors. The harbor office asks pleasure boats to keep clear of the channel when the ferry is expected.

Thunderstorms are short but sharp. The keeper's old rule still applies: when the far headland disappears, everyone comes in.

Autumn

The sea is warm and the nights draw in. Gales return in October, and with them the first of the winter closures.

Autumn tides are the highest of the year. The sea wall was built to hold them back, and it has done so for a century.

Notes

Tide tables are printed each December for the following year and are free at the harbor office.

Corrections are noted in the margin of the office copy and posted on the quay board.

Readers are invited to send observations of unusual weather to the office, with the date and time.

A summary of each year's observations is added to the almanac, so that later readers can compare one winter with another.